

Figure 2.3 *Ahangaran, surroundings and banks of Hari Rud. © Photograph Jawan Shir Rasikh, c. 2010.*

livestock as well as hand-made objects and textiles.[26] The wide spectrum of lifestyles within the Ahangaran Valley, certainly in the present day and probably also in the past, reiterates the conceptual importance of the nomad–urban continuum for understanding not only the Shansabanis' forebears and their milieu of origin but also, as we shall see below, their later imperial history.

By the mid-twelfth century (*c.* AH 539/1145 CE), the Hari Rud boasted a second Shansabani-affiliated site at its confluence with the Jam Rud. The probable Shansabani summer "capital" of Jam-Firuzkuh (Figure 2.2) was established quite possibly in the vicinity of a primarily Jewish settlement already existing nearby as of the early eleventh century.[27] The site received notable architectural patronage probably upon its inception, which continued through AH 565–575/1170s CE and perhaps later (see esp. Chapters 3–5). Farther west of Jam-Firuzkuh lay Chisht and Awbeh, the last two being eastern satellites within the orbit of the great Khurasani emporium of Herat. Ghur's eastern flank beyond Chagcharan already touched upon the mountainous edges of Bamiyan and its many valleys. Thus, northern Mandesh and especially Darmashan – edging Badghis, Faryab, and Sar-i Pul provinces on modern maps – most likely formed the northern arc of historical Ghur as understood by the Shansabanis' eleventh- and twelfth-century forebears.

According to Juzjani, even after the Shansabanis' emergence as a prominent regional power in the mid-twelfth century, at least some of the elites and their entourages and other followers continued to undertake annual, seasonally determined migrations along a northeast–southwesterly axis. The